

THE LOONY LANDSCAPE

If there was any proof needed of a system in a time warp, this is it

VIKRAM SHARMA



PAID TO PLAY: Government employees on a lunch break in Delhi

HILL AREA ALLOWANCE

For those posted at hill stations situated at a height of 1,000 m or more above sea level. Ranges from Rs 100 at the lowest grade to Rs 300 at the highest grade.

BAD CLIMATE ALLOWANCE

For those posted in bad climate locations. Ranges from Rs 40 or Rs 1.33 per day at the lowest level to Rs 200 at the top.

REMOTE LOCALITY ALLOWANCE

Granted to employees in remote localities—Little Andaman to Dudu in J&K to Aizwal. Rs 40 for class IV to Rs 1,300 at the top.

GANDHINAGAR ALLOWANCE

Central government employees are entitled to 2.5 per cent of pay (basic + dearness pay), if posted in Gandhinagar.

BORDER AREA ALLOWANCE

For those posted within 16 km of the international border in Punjab and 30 miles of the international border in Rajasthan.

SPECIAL DUTY ALLOWANCE

At the rate of 12.5 per cent of pay, for those posted in the North-east—Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Nagaland, Sikkim and Tripura—from outside the region.

ISLAND DUTY ALLOWANCE

If posted in Andaman & Nicobar islands and Lakshadweep, civilians are entitled to get 12.5 per cent to 25 per cent of pay (basic + dearness pay) depending on location.

PROJECT ALLOWANCE

For lack of amenities such as schools, markets and healthcare in major project areas, employees are paid Rs 150-750 per month depending on their levels.

TRIBAL AREA ALLOWANCE

Granted in tribal pockets of Andhra Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Orissa, Tamil Nadu, Tripura, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal.

SUNDERBANS ALLOWANCE

Employees in Sunderbans are paid between Rs 30 and Rs 120 per month.

HARD AREA ALLOWANCE

For those in the Nicobar group of islands, at 25 per cent of basic + DP + stagnation increment and NPA subject to conditions.

CYCLE ALLOWANCE

Given where duties assigned to a post require extensive travel. Rs 30 per month is paid provided "head of department is satisfied about admissibility of allowance".

CASH HANDLING ALLOWANCE

For cashiers! Ranging from Rs 75 for handling up to Rs 50,000 to Rs 300 for handling cash over Rs 10 lakh.

CARETAKING ALLOWANCE

For caretakers of buildings! Group C and Group D employees are paid Rs 200 and Rs 100, respectively.

tion with the system better than former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi. At the Congress Centenary in 1985, he said, "We have government servants who do not serve but oppress the poor and the helpless, police who do not uphold the law but shield the guilty, tax collectors who do not collect taxes but connive with those who cheat the state and whole legions whose only concern is their own welfare at the cost of society." This may sound harsh in the politically correct new millennium but is no less true today for those suffering the system.

Government officials should no doubt be paid better remuneration. But a just system requires institution of performance benchmarks, not just rewards. Sure there is an Administrative Reforms Panel working on restructuring government but history gives little hope as every previous panel's recommendations were rejected. Indeed, the Fifth Pay Commission's suggestion to cut the flab by 30 per cent and abolish 3,50,000 vacant posts had met the same fate.

Today the perception is that what works is in the private sector and what is holding back India is in public domain. The 19th century machinery we call government needs overhaul. The Centre is a conceptual myth. Every inch of India is ruled by state governments. So the first step would be to get rid of all ministries which duplicate the functions of state governments. The Centre must also transfer the powers of implementing Central schemes to Panchayati Raj institutions. The money saved in slashing of posts and vacation of precious real estate should release enough money for trebling social sector spend. This will empower those at the bottom of the pyramid. Perhaps the government also needs to take a lesson in modern methods of compensation. Singapore, for instance, makes a lump sum payment and has done away with perks like housing.

The economic rationale is also the political logic. Since the 1980s, parties lose 60 per cent of sitting candidates every poll and wonder how to tackle anti-incumbency. In vain they struggle with new alliances to retain power. They need to realise that anti-incumbency is simply their inability to make the babudom deliver. They should learn to ride the beast, not fear it and feed its every whim.

with bureau reports

Rs 2,290

**IS THE FEE PAID
BY A SECRETARY
FOR OCCUPYING A
BUNGALOW BESIDES
FOREGOING
RS 8,600 AS HRA.**